Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on John

Literary concepts that **MIGHT** be used in a discussion of Owens's poem include

allusion,
consonance,
free verse,
metonymy,
muse,
parenthesis,
pun,
speaker,
symbol,
tactile imagery,
tone,
visual imagery, and
zeugma.

The contestant should find, in Owens's recounting of her adolescent crush, evidence that idealized physical beauty has the power to inspire. The approach might be subjective, or it might be a more generalized assessment of the role that art—graphic, plastic, literary, or indeed cinematic—plays in the development of a person's appreciation of beauty—and by extension a person's development as a writer, specifically as a poet.

Any referencing of Samuel Taylor Coleridge's poetry as homage to Nature's ability to inspire the poet is welcomed and should be recognized as a response to the prompt.